

22 experienced object (anubhūtārtha). It also does not have anything ultimately existent (paramārthasat) as its intentional object, since its intentional object is devoid of the three times, like a sky-flower. Certainly, an utterance, “He should do this,” (kuryād) does not refer to the present. For then it would have the same content as the utterance, “He does this.” It is not the case that it refers to the future, like the utterance, “He will do this.” It is also not the case that it refers to the past, like the utterance, “He did this.” Pratibhā is not a means of knowing, since its intentional object is non-existent. It is not a doubt, since it involves exclusive determination. It is not an error, since it makes everyone undertake actions everywhere.³⁰ According to Vācaspati, instances of pratibhā represent an action as something to be done. This, in turn, gives rise to an awareness of the action along with its goal, the means to achieve it, and the way to perform it, and results in the performance of the action. This action may be something mundane, like cooking pasta, where the goal of the action is the prepared pasta, the means of action involves the ingredients and utensils needed for cooking, and the way to do it is laid out in the recipe. People have performed this action in the past, are perhaps performing it now, and will perform it in the future. In that sense, it may be described by means of declarative sentences. This is why Vācaspati says that the action in question may be delimited by the three times. The catch, however, is this. Even though the action in question may be delimited by the three times, it is represented by instances of pratibhā as delimited by neither the past, nor the present, nor the future. That ensures that the content of that awareness cannot be expressed by means of declarative sentences like, “He does this,” “He will do this,” and “He did this.” In this respect, pratibhā, unlike our other sources of knowledge, is directed at an object that is ultimately non-existent. Yet, it is not uncertain in the same way as a state of doubt is. It decisively tells the agent what is to be done. Moreover, since it gives rise to successful action everywhere, it also is not like a state of error. The lesson: an instance of pratibhā is an awareness which does not represent an action as something that an agent has performed, or is performing, or will perform. In this respect, it does not have any descriptive content at all: it has a distinctively normative content. In this respect, the relevant theory of pratibhā is distinct from the Vaiśeṣika theory of pratibhā that Maṇḍana criticises elsewhere (see footnote 25). For the Vaiśeṣikas, the content of pratibhā, e.g., in the case of the girl’s premonition that her brother will arrive the next day, or in the farmer’s premonition that it will rain, is descriptive. But, on this theory, it is irreducibly normative. ³⁰ NK on VV §11.3, 485.3-11: na hi te pratibhāvido ye saṃvedanam anīścayātmakam pratibhām ācakhyuḥ | saṃśayo hi saḥ | vyaṃ tu sādhyasādhaneetikartavyatāvacchinnāyāḥ kriyāyāḥ pratipattāv anukūlām tatpratipattyā kārye ’nuṣṭhānalakṣaṇe kartavye saḥakāriṇīm kartavyam iti prajñām pratibhām adhyagīṣmahi | evaṃ tarhi kriyaivāsyā viśaya iti na nirviśayety āha – pratibheti | kriyāviśayatve hi kriyāpratītiḥ | sā ca traikālyāvacchinnakriyāgocarā yathā pacati pakṣyaty apākṣīd iti | iyaṃ punar atītānāgatavartamānānām anyatamenāpy anavacchinnaṃ anubhūtārtham iva pratibhāsayantī pratibhā | na punar asyāḥ paramārthasadvīṣayaḥ kālatrayarahitavāt khapuṣpavat | na khalu kuryād iti vartamānākhyā karotīty avīśeṣaprasaṅgāt | nānāgatā kariṣyatīti | nātītā akārṣīd iti | tad eṣā na pramāṇam asadvīṣayatvāt | na saṃśayaḥ ekāntāvasāyāt | na viparyayaḥ sarveṣāṃ sarvatra vyavahārapravartanāt | For a variant, see VVMG 176.6-18.